I asked, "Who's going to win the World Series?"

The recording said, "I beg your pardon?"

I said, "Never mind."

I suppose the recording was meant to be reassuring. But I later learned that the recording was covering up for somebody. That somebody—the only one who really understands retirement benefits—is a massive computer. The calculation is far too complicated for mere human minds to grasp.

Still, I persisted. After checking libraries and taking another crack at the handbook, I was able to piece together a framework.

First, I learned that if you've paid Social Security tax for ten or more years, you're fully vested. That means you'll get 100 percent of your calculated benefit at age 62 or 65, even if you retire young. Second, your calculated benefit is based on your "average earnings" up to the maximum—i.e., $43,800 in 1987. (The computer adjusts for changes in the maximum over the years.) In making the calculation, the computer throws out your lowest five years. So at least five zero-earning years are "free" in that they don't reduce your "average earnings."

But here's where it gets tricky. What happens to your "average earnings" and related benefits if you have more than five years of zero earnings? Do *all* the low years get thrown out, like the phone recording says? I never got a clear answer to that question. I could have tried to go straight to the computer. But I was told that the computer refuses to see anyone under age 60. You can hardly blame it, given the law's propensity to change.

So I took the worst case and assumed that "average earnings" go down as a result of factoring in the zero-earning years. And I found that, the way the computer sees things, your retirement benefits go down proportionately far less than "average earnings."

By way of illustration, suppose you have fifteen zero-earning years after throwing out the five freebies. And sup-